

on WhatsApp on video calls in terms of styling. So we literally are of a firm view that we are a consumer-backed business and not a channel-backed business.

Q: And in terms of a geographical break-up, could you give me a sense of where most of your growth is coming in from—still the metros or primarily B&C cities?

A: I would say in the past few years, growth from the Tier II and Tier III cities has... seen a huge spike. Some of it is market dynamics, as a lot of people moved there [to non-metros]. But, I would say we're still a 60 per cent metro-driven business today. However, there's a huge untapped opportunity in Tier II and Tier III markets; it is on our radar and we will get there step by step.

Q: Do you have any international aspirations or is the India opportunity so large that most of your mind space will continue to be focussed on addressing the home market?

A: Over the past two years, we have been piloting the Lenskart proposition in some international markets like Singapore and we see positive results. India is a large opportunity and we still have a lot of work to do here. But we are not a company that only thinks three years ahead. We are thinking 7-10 years ahead and from that perspective, we have to think international.

But, I must tell you that the transformation that has happened in eyewear in India is parallel to none. There is no other geography in the world where a transformation has happened at this pace. Having said that, when we look at the scope, the opportunity exists all over the globe for us. So, globally I would say 4.5 billion people need glasses, 2 billion people still don't have access to glasses or they don't get glasses for whatever reason. In India this number may be 75 per cent, but even globally that number is 50 per cent! The myopia rate today, in most parts of the world, is 50

ON GROWTH

We grew about 60 per cent-plus last year, and are on track to deliver another 50 per cent-plus growth in FY23.

ON FUND-RAISING

A lot of the money raised at Lenskart, which the media reports about, is secondary [fundraising]. The capital we have raised lately is for investments in the long-term like building supply chain and technology. We don't burn operating capital.

ON ONLINE VS OFFLINE CHANNELS

The two feed into each other. I would say that the lines between channels are diminishing. If you look at the last four- or five-year trajectory, you would see that consumers overlap between these channels.

ON THE EYEWEAR SPACE IN INDIA

There are 400 million-plus people who need glasses and are not wearing them. The market is growing about 20-30 per cent every year.

per cent. If you look at Asia, the Southeast Asia number is already 80 per cent. So yeah, if we want Lenskart to be the Microsoft of eyewear or Amazon of eyewear, we do have to have global aspirations and invest in it for the long term.

Q: But the giant there is Luxottica with an almost \$75-billion market cap last I checked; do you intend to gun for their position at some point in the future?

A: From an impact perspective, why not? You know, it's difficult to build business valuation backwards or market cap backwards, but in terms of the impact, absolutely! I will say that we definitely want to pack a lot more people in that revenue; we constantly feel that there is half of the world that is left out. We also believe that if there was a Netflix to Disney, there has to be a Lenskart to Luxottica, right? So from that perspective, yes, we do. We do have aspirations of creating a global impact.

Q: Finally, I want to ask you about the *Shark Tank* experience because you became quite the popular participant there. What was that experience like?

A: I'm a fan of *Shark Tank*. I have grown up in this entrepreneurial journey watching it, and when the opportunity came, I literally got advised by my family and my co-founders to not say no to this. Well, I would say it was a great experience, more so from a learning perspective. Getting out there, meeting entrepreneurs from across the country, I could see that the pace at which we used to do things is very different from the pace at which the new generation is doing things. I also saw that if we used to do something in \$10, people are now doing it in under \$1, and they're doing it in less time. So, I was able to bring back a lot of fresh perspectives and learning to my own business. It has been great to partner with some of these entrepreneurs. I go back and talk to my team now, ask them why are we not doing this? Tell them this is where the world is moving. So, all in all, it's been way richer than I thought it would be. **BT**